

NC.5 Forms & Documents Index

Every document a North Carolina owner-builder meets — what each one is, when it is needed, and which office it comes from.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. North Carolina permits are administered by 100 counties and dozens of municipalities, and local requirements vary. Confirm every item with the inspections department that will issue your permit before you rely on it. Form names and numbers are local; the obligations behind them are not.

Documents a North Carolina owner-builder will encounter

Document	What it is and when you need it	Where it comes from
Building permit application	The main application. Triggers the \$40,000 tests for licensure, workers' comp, and lien agent. When: after zoning, septic and erosion control are lined up.	City, town, or county inspections department
Owner exemption affidavit	A <i>verified</i> — i.e. sworn and notarized — affidavit that you own the land, will personally superintend the work, and will attend every inspection. When: at application. The department forwards a copy to the Licensing Board, which verifies your claim.	Inspections department form; notary required
Workers' compensation proof or affirmation	Proof of coverage "as required by Chapter 97," which reaches employers of three or more. With no employees you affirm that instead. When: at application.	Inspections department form — wording varies by county
Appointment of lien agent	Required at \$40,000 or more, before you first contract with anyone to improve the property. You choose from the registry of lien agents kept by the Department of Insurance. New construction is not exempt — the exemption covers improvements to an <i>existing</i> owner-occupied dwelling.	Commonly filed at liensnc.com ; \$30 published appointment fee for a 1-2 family dwelling
Permit posting / lien agent sign	The building permit must be conspicuously and continuously posted on the property until construction is complete. If the permit does not carry the lien agent's contact information, a sign disclosing it must be posted instead.	You post it — nobody reminds you
Erosion and sedimentation control plan	Required when land disturbance exceeds one acre . Must be filed at least 30 days before disturbance begins and approved before the building permit may issue.	NC DEQ land resources program, or a delegated local program — ask which applies in your county

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Septic — three approvals in sequence	Improvement Permit (IP) follows the soil and site evaluation and establishes that the site will support a system, and what kind. Construction Authorization (CA) lets it be built. Operation Permit is issued after installation and inspection, and is what lets the system be used. Your building permit cannot issue until the CA has — statewide, not a local quirk. When: start the IP as early as possible — before you buy the land if you still can.	County (local) health department, under 15A NCAC 18E
Well construction permit + Certificate of Completion	The permit is required before a private drinking water well is constructed, and is valid five years. After construction the health department inspects and issues a Certificate of Completion — the well may not be placed in service without it. The department then samples the water within 30 days; you do not arrange that yourself.	County health department, under 15A NCAC 02C .0300
Driveway / access permit	Normally not required for a single residence. NCDOT's rule excludes residential driveway connections unless there is a safety hazard, a highway project, or excessive/obvious drainage complications. Contact the District Engineer anyway — they flag design issues and arrange your driveway pipe.	NCDOT District Engineer if the road is state-maintained; otherwise the city or county
Trade permits — electrical, plumbing, mechanical	Separate permits are required for plumbing systems, heating and cooling equipment, and electrical wiring, in addition to the building permit. Doing the work yourself under the owner exemption does not waive them.	Inspections department — some counties bundle these into one permit
Certificate of compliance	Issued after the final inspection when the completed work complies. This is the statutory name for what everyone calls the certificate of occupancy. Occupying before it issues is a Class 1 misdemeanor.	Inspections department, at the end
Temporary certificate of occupancy	May be issued for a stated period, for all or part of the building, if the inspector finds it may safely be occupied before final completion.	Inspections department, on request

Sources (verified August 2026, General Statutes at ncleg.gov): affidavit and workers' comp proof — § 87-14(a)(1), (a)(2), with Chapter 97 reaching employers of three or more, § 97-2(1). Lien agent at \$40,000+, designated before first contracting, chosen from the Department of Insurance registry — § 44A-11.1(a), (b); details on the permit — § 160D-1110(g); permit posted continuously, or a lien agent sign — § 44A-11.2(d), (e). Separate plumbing, mechanical and electrical permits — § 160D-1110(a). Erosion plan over one acre filed 30 days ahead — § 113A-57(4). Certificate of compliance, temporary CO, and the occupancy penalty — § 160D-1116. Septic IP / CA / OP and the building-permit gate — 15A NCAC 18E, § .0204(f). Well permit, Certificate of Completion, and the health department's 30-day sampling duty — 15A NCAC 02C .0304, .0306(c) and 15A NCAC 18A .3802(a). Residential driveway exclusion — 19A NCAC 02B § .0601(a). The \$30 appointment fee is LiensNC's published fee for a 1-2 family dwelling, not a statutory one — confirm it at liensnc.com before you budget it.